DEXKOR

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CUSTOMER OPERATIONS

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— A PLAYBOOK FOR THE AI ERA —

The Scaling *CX* Playbook

How B2B SaaS leaders are rebuilding their support function — for half the cost, twice the output, and a fraction of the burnout.

9 PLAYS · 1 MODERN STACK ·
FIELD-TESTED WITH SAAS OPERATORS

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If your renewal email made your stomach drop, *this is for you.*

Somewhere between Q3 board prep and the next product launch, the email arrives. Your helpdesk renewal. The number is up thirty, sometimes fifty percent. Your team is the same size. Your tickets are not.

That email is the most expensive paragraph of text most CX leaders read all year. Not because of the price tag, but because of what comes next: the all-hands conversation about doing more with less, the headcount freeze that follows, the slow erosion of the response times you spent two years improving.

This guide exists because we kept hearing the same sentence in customer conversations: *"We are paying enterprise prices for tooling that was built for a different decade."* The instinct is to push back on price. The opportunity is bigger than that. The category itself is being rewritten. AI changed what a helpdesk can do. The operating model has not yet caught up. The leaders who recognize this first are about to spend the next two years widening the gap on the ones who do not.

Inside, you will find nine plays we have seen work — across SaaS teams of fifty, three hundred, and a few thousand people. Some are reframes. Some are worksheets. One is a checklist to run before signing your next contract. None of them require buying anything from us. All of them will make you a sharper buyer when you do.

A NOTE ON WHAT THIS IS NOT

This is not a vendor pitch. It is a field guide. We have tried to write it the way we would talk about it over coffee — with specifics, screenshots of real workflows where helpful, and the kind of plain-spoken framing your CFO will actually engage with. If by page fifteen you want to keep talking, that is the only ask.

Inside this *volume.*

Each play is self-contained. Read in order, or jump to the one that fits the conversation you are about to have with your CFO.

The decade-old stack is *quietly bankrupting* modern support teams.

Three forces are converging on the desks of CX leaders right now. Any one of them would be a hard quarter. Together, they are a category reset.

1 — The Renewal Squeeze

Legacy helpdesk vendors are repricing aggressively. Renewals up thirty to fifty percent are now standard, often paired with feature gates that push customers toward higher tiers. The unit economics that worked at Series A no longer work at Series B.

2 — The Volume Spike

Ticket volume is no longer linear with revenue. Self-serve growth, free tiers, and AI-curious customers send three to five times more inbound. Your headcount budget did not get a memo.

3 — The AI Mandate

Boards are asking the same question in every CX review: *"What is our AI story?"* Most teams have a Slackbot, a half-trained macro library, and a vendor add-on that costs extra. None of it has reduced ticket volume meaningfully.

The Result

The CX function is being asked to scale three times without scaling cost. That is not a productivity problem. It is an architecture problem. And it cannot be solved by the same stack that created it.

> *"The leaders who treat this moment as a renewal negotiation will save ten percent. The leaders who treat it as an architecture decision will save half their cost stack and double their output."*

Audit your *true* cost per ticket.

Most teams know their helpdesk seat price. Almost none can name their true cost per resolved ticket. The gap is where the real budget lives.

The stated price of your helpdesk is a fraction of what each ticket actually costs you to resolve. When CFOs benchmark CX, they look at one number — fully-loaded cost per resolved ticket — and most CX teams cannot produce it on demand. Build it once, keep it on a one-pager, and the renewal conversation flips.

The hidden stack typically includes four buckets that never appear on the helpdesk invoice: agent time lost to tool-switching, supervisor time lost to manual reporting, tickets resolved on Slack or email outside the system entirely, and the price of every adjacent tool you bolted on because the core product could not do the job.

— WORKSHEET —

Your true cost per resolved ticket

Helpdesk software (annual ÷ 12, divided by monthly tickets)	*$ ___ / ticket*
Adjacent tools: knowledge base, surveys, voice, chat add-ons	*$ ___ / ticket*
Fully-loaded agent time per ticket (incl. tool-switching, ~30%)	*$ ___ / ticket*
Supervisor & reporting overhead	*$ ___ / ticket*
Tickets resolved off-system (Slack, email, DMs) & rework cost	*$ ___ / ticket*
True fully-loaded cost per resolved ticket	***$ ___***

Map where you sit in the *three eras* of support.

Your vendor is not your problem. Your decade is. Most teams are running an Era Two stack inside an Era Three world — and wondering why nothing scales.

— ERA ONE —

1995–2010

The Queue. Tickets routed by humans. Email was the channel. Reporting meant exporting a CSV at month-end. Helpdesk was a cost center, full stop.

— ERA TWO —

2010–2023

The Cloud Stack. Zendesk era. SaaS integrations. Macros and triggers. Decent dashboards. A point tool for every channel, all stitched together with workflow automation.

— ERA THREE —

2024–

AI-Native. Agents that resolve, not route. Full customer context surfaced in seconds. The helpdesk merges with onboarding, success, and revenue ops in one operating layer.

How to tell which era you are in

- **You are in Era One** if your team is still doing manual triage and most reporting lives in spreadsheets. Rare in modern SaaS, but more common than admitted.
- **You are in Era Two** if your stack is a helpdesk plus four to seven adjacent tools, and at least one of them is on its own renewal cycle this year. This is most B2B SaaS teams today.
- **You are in Era Three** if AI is doing meaningful resolution work — not just suggesting replies — and your operating model is built around outcomes, not tickets.

> *The cost of being half a decade behind your buyers is no longer measured in CSAT. It is measured in churn.*

Adopt a modern CX *operating model.*

A helpdesk is a tool. An operating model is what scales. The teams pulling away right now have collapsed ten point tools into four operating layers.

— LAYER 01	**Channels.** Every inbound and outbound conversation, unified. Email, chat, voice, in-app, social, WhatsApp — one inbox, one record, one identity.
— LAYER 02	**Workflows.** Routing, SLA, escalation, and approvals as code. No swivel-chair handoffs between tools. Triggers fire across the whole customer journey, not just within support.
— LAYER 03	**Intelligence.** AI agents that read context, draft replies, summarize threads, detect sentiment, and resolve where they can. Humans handle the conversations that need a human.
— LAYER 04	**Outcomes.** Real-time visibility into resolution time, CSAT, deflection rate, and revenue impact. A reporting layer your CEO actually opens.

When these four layers run on a single platform — instead of a helpdesk plus six bolt-ons — the cost stack collapses by thirty to forty percent and the team's surface area for context-switching drops by an order of magnitude. That is the productivity gain. AI is the multiplier on top.

Demand AI that *actually works.*

There is a widening gap between AI as a marketing line item and AI as a measurable resolution lever. Most CX leaders cannot tell which is which from a sixty-minute demo. Here is the filter.

Vendor AI today falls into three buckets: cosmetic, assistive, and resolutive. Cosmetic AI summarizes a thread or suggests a canned reply — useful, but does not move your numbers. Assistive AI drafts in context, retrieves customer history, routes by sentiment — moves productivity ten to twenty percent. Resolutive AI closes tickets autonomously inside guardrails — moves the cost equation entirely.

If a vendor cannot show you, in the demo, exactly how many tickets per week their AI resolves end-to-end without human touch — and at what confidence threshold — assume their AI is cosmetic, regardless of what the deck says.

— FIVE QUESTIONS TO ASK IN EVERY AI DEMO —

01 **What percentage of our tickets would your AI resolve without human touch?** Ask for a number on your data, not theirs.

02 **How does the AI handle a ticket it should not auto-resolve?** The escalation logic matters more than the resolution logic.

03 **What customer context does the AI have access to?** Past tickets, account health, billing status, product usage — or just the open thread?

04 **How is the AI improved?** Ask about retraining cadence, feedback loops, and how your team's corrections close the loop.

05 **What happens if the AI is wrong?** Audit trail, override path, and the human-in-the-loop workflow. If they hesitate, leave.

Unify the inbox, or *lose the customer.*

Channel fragmentation, not ticket volume, is the real CSAT killer. Customers do not care which channel they used yesterday. Your tooling should not either.

The average B2B SaaS customer touches your support function across three to five channels in a single quarter — email, in-app chat, a Slack Connect channel, a WhatsApp DM to their CSM, and a voice call when something breaks. In most stacks, each of those lives in a different tool, with a different ticket ID, owned by a different team. The customer experiences this as four separate companies.

The fix is not "add another channel." The fix is collapsing every conversation into one identity layer, with one customer record, one history, and one set of SLAs. When a ticket arrives in chat at 11 AM and an email at 4 PM about the same issue, your system should already know.

What unification actually unlocks

- **Resolution speed** — agents stop asking "what did we already discuss?" because the context is one click away, regardless of channel.
- **Lower volume** — duplicate tickets disappear because the system recognizes the same customer and the same issue across channels.
- **Real CSAT** — measured at the customer level, not the ticket level, which is the only number that correlates with renewal.
- **Revenue signal** — a single record means support data finally informs success and sales decisions in the same week, not the next quarter.

> *A fragmented inbox is the most expensive customer-experience tax most B2B teams pay without ever putting it on a P&L line.*

Defuse the *migration myth.*

The number-one reason CX leaders stay in a tool they have outgrown is the fear of moving. The fear is well-founded. The math has changed.

Migration trauma is real, but it is dated. It belongs to an era when knowledge bases were exported as PDFs, ticket history did not transfer cleanly, and three months of dual-running burned out the team. The modern playbook compresses migration to fourteen days for most B2B SaaS teams under three hundred agents.

The 14-Day Migration Playbook

01 **Days 1–3 — Discovery & Mapping.** Inventory current tickets, channels, integrations, macros, SLAs, and reporting needs. Map every workflow to the new system. Identify what dies, what merges, what stays.

02 **Days 4–7 — Configuration & Import.** Stand up the new platform, import historical tickets and knowledge base, configure routing and SLAs. Pilot team — usually three to five agents — runs live in parallel.

03 **Days 8–11 — Dual Run.** All agents on the new system, legacy stays read-only for reference. AI agents are tuned against your real ticket flow. Daily fifteen-minute standups catch friction early.

04 **Days 12–14 — Cut-over & Stabilize.** Legacy goes read-only-archive. New system is the source of truth. The only thing left is uninstalling the old browser bookmarks.

Two principles make this work: a concierge migration team that owns the timeline, and a guardrailed dual-run period. If your prospective vendor cannot offer both, the fourteen-day promise is a marketing line.

Build your ROI case *on one page.*

If your CFO has to read two pages, you have already lost. The case for change is not a deck — it is a side-by-side. Here is the template.

THE LINE ITEM	CURRENT STATE	MODERN STACK
Helpdesk software (annual)	$ ___ (renewal +30–50%)	$ ___ (consolidated)
Adjacent tools (KB, survey, voice, chat add-ons)	$ ___ across 4–7 line items	$ 0 — built into platform
Agent productivity loss to tool-switching	~30% of agent time	~10% of agent time
AI-resolved tickets / month	< 5% (cosmetic AI)	25–40% (resolutive AI)
Reporting overhead (supervisor hrs/mo)	15–25 hrs	2–4 hrs
Time to first response (median)	3–6 hours	< 30 minutes
Implied capacity for next year's volume growth	Linear with headcount	2–3x without headcount

— THE CFO SENTENCE —

"Consolidating to a modern stack reduces our fully-loaded cost per resolved ticket by approximately X percent while increasing capacity by Y percent — equivalent to Z FTEs of headcount we will not need to add this year."

Reframe support as a *profit center.*

The board deck question is no longer "how do we cut support cost." It is "how do we turn support into a retention and expansion engine." The leaders who pre-empt that pivot get the budget.

For two decades, support was the thing you optimized to spend less on. That framing is now actively dangerous. Your support function sits on the highest-fidelity signal in your business — what your customers struggle with, in their words, in real time. That signal, fed back into success, product, and sales, is the cheapest expansion revenue you will ever generate.

Three numbers that make the case

- **Net Revenue Retention.** A one-point lift in NRR is typically worth more than a fifteen-point lift in new logo acquisition for a Series B B2B SaaS. Support quality is the single largest input to NRR you can move in a quarter.
- **Expansion velocity.** Customers who experience a fast, on-context support resolution in their first ninety days expand at roughly two times the rate of those who do not. Support is the leading indicator of expansion, not the trailing one.
- **Churn signal lead time.** A unified CX layer surfaces churn risk thirty to sixty days earlier than CRM does. That window is the difference between a save and a loss.

> *Stop budgeting support as a cost line. Start budgeting it as the operating layer of your retention and expansion motion. The number changes. The conversation changes faster.*

The practical implication for the CX leader: stop benchmarking only on CSAT and resolution time. Start reporting on revenue impact — saved accounts, accelerated expansions, churn prevented — in the same monthly review as your operational metrics. The first leader to put a dollar number next to a support function in a board pack rarely loses budget again.

Run the *seven-question* renewal test.

Before you sign anything — your current vendor's renewal, a competitor's contract, a multi-year discount — sit with these seven questions for ten minutes. Most renewals do not survive them.

01 **Does my vendor's AI roadmap have a real shipping cadence?** Or is the AI page on their site doing more work than their changelog?

02 **Am I paying per-agent prices for tools my agents do not use?** Pull the seat-utilization report. The gap is your real overpayment.

03 **Can my agents see full customer context in under ten seconds?** Time it during your next escalation. The answer is rarely yes.

04 **Do I know my fully-loaded cost per resolved ticket?** If not, you are not negotiating — you are guessing.

05 **If volume tripled tomorrow, what would my bill look like?** If the answer scales linearly with seats, your stack is not modern.

06 **Has my CSAT improved year over year on this stack?** If it has plateaued or fallen, the tool is no longer the answer to the problem.

07 **Am I signing this multi-year deal because I want to, or because switching feels too hard?** The honest answer is the answer.

— WHAT TO DO WITH THE ANSWERS —

If three or more answers point in the wrong direction, do not sign a multi-year. Negotiate a one-year extension while you run a structured evaluation. The cost of a year of optionality is almost always less than the cost of a wrong three-year commitment.

How a logistics SaaS rebuilt its support stack *in a quarter.*

Names and details lightly anonymized. Numbers are real.

The company was a 130-person logistics SaaS in its Series B. Support team of eighteen agents across two time zones. The trigger was familiar: a renewal quote up thirty-eight percent, a board mandate for an "AI story," and a head of CX who had inherited a stack of seven tools.

The team ran a structured evaluation across three vendors over six weeks. The decision criteria were simple — one platform replacing four, AI that resolved meaningfully on their own ticket data, and a migration timeline that did not require a hiring freeze.

14d
TOTAL MIGRATION TIME

32%
TIER-1 TICKETS AI-RESOLVED

−87%
REPORTING TIME SAVED

+6
POINTS OF CSAT LIFT

4 → 1
TOOLS CONSOLIDATED

What changed in ninety days

Median first-response time dropped from four hours to under thirty minutes. AI resolved roughly thirty-two percent of tier-one tickets without human touch by day sixty. Reporting time for the CX leader dropped from two days to forty minutes per month. CSAT moved up six points. The next quarter's headcount ask was withdrawn.

DexKor.

What does *your* stack look like, on a modern operating layer?

If you found something useful in these pages, the next step is twenty minutes. We will look at your real ticket volume, your real cost stack, and show you — with specifics — what the same operation looks like rebuilt on DexKor HelpDesk.

BOOK A 20-MIN WORKING SESSION →

READ THE FIELD NOTES

— WHAT YOU WILL LEAVE WITH —

A one-page side-by-side of your current cost stack against a consolidated DexKor stack. A directional ROI number for your CFO. A migration sketch with timing. No deck, no follow-up sequence — just the answer to whether this is worth a deeper look.

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